



darling of the crowd," Nasser added. A potential solution to revive interest could be creating space in the national calendar to ensure the availability of India's regular players. Olympian Mohammed Riyaz sees this as a way to bring back the crowds.

"I have requested the [Hockey India] secretary and president to demarcate the top five tournaments in the Indian calendar where the national team can participate. Only then can these tournaments become more globalised, attracting more spectators. It will also improve the overall viewership," he said.

Sunil Kumar Singh, coach of RSPB, echoed this sentiment. "During these top tournaments, if Hockey India's calendar is not busy and they can release the national players, the charm of these events will be restored," he said. "The quality of matches will improve, and the players who primarily play in domestic events will get a chance to

test themselves against high-quality internationals," he added.

Despite the decline in attendance over the years, the importance of this legacy event remains undeniable. Baskaran credits the tournament with helping to discover talented players from Odisha. "In the 1990s, the army team started participating and many Odisha players emerged. The Army Services teams had players like Vincent Lakra and Gopal Bhengra, who played here and caught the attention of selectors," the former coach said.

"These tournaments have paved the way for many youngsters to go on and play in the Olympics or the World Cup," Baskaran added.

In the recently concluded edition, one match was held under floodlights each day to allow more spectators to catch the live action. According to Baskaran, the organisers have also proposed a women's tournament, which could be held simultaneously in the future.

Halcyon days: Indian hockey legend Dhanraj Pillay was a fan favourite, drawing large crowds to the stadium during the golden days of the MCC-Murugappa Gold Cup. M. VEDHAN



Legacy tournaments

Beighton Cup, Kolkata

- 125th edition held this year

All India MCC-Murugappa Gold Cup

- 95th edition held this year
Aga Khan Tournament, Mumbai - last held in 2011

Bombay Gold Cup, Mumbai

- last held in 2020
Obaidullah Khan Heritage Cup, Bhopal - last held in 2022

Maharaja Ranjit Singh tournament, Amritsar

- last held in 2019

All India Shri Guru Gobind Singh ji Gold and Silver Cup Hockey Tournament

- 50th edition held this year in Nanded

Nehru Senior Hockey Tournament, New Delhi

- 60th edition held this year

All India Trades Cup Hockey Tournament

- 99th edition held in Nainital this year

Mahant Raja Sarweshwardas Memorial All India Hockey Tournament

- 80th edition held this year in Rajnandgaon, Chhattisgarh

All India Police Hockey Championship

- 72nd edition held in Jammu this year